

Global Strategy Weekly

Nothing to see here... just a bond market meltdown



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The title is a quote from June 2007 when bond yields last reached these lofty levels. Back then, rising bond yields ‘broke’ the US economy and markets. Each cycle is different, but could the current bond rout trigger another equity market collapse?

■ I’ve made a habit of reading the excellent daily email from Bloomberg’s John Authers propped up in bed with my morning cup of tea. Today’s article, [**Bond Market Fright May End Cheap Funds Era**](#), highlighted that the current bond market rout has taken 30y US yields back up to 5.2% for the first time since June 2007. That date is auspicious.

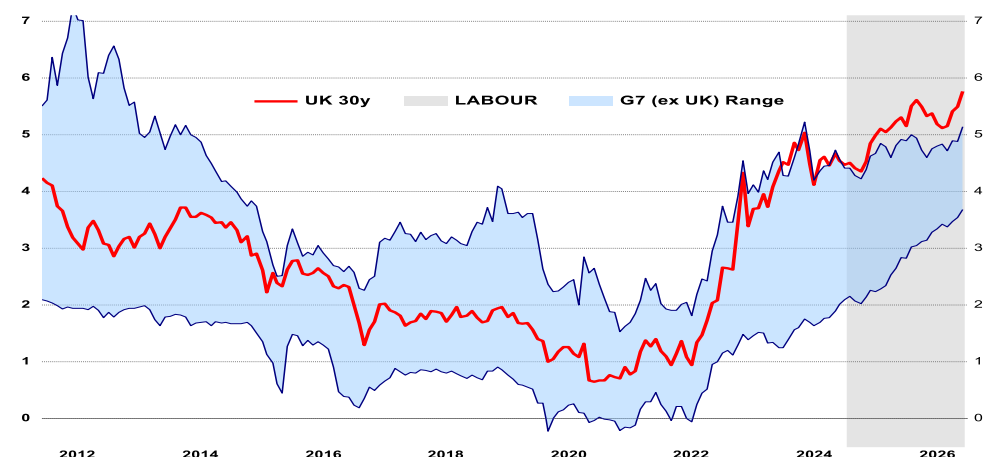
■ Authers’ article looks at the similarities and differences between where we are now and the summer of 2007. He repeats a quote from his analysis at the time (17 June 2007 FT article, [here](#)), “Bond yields are not high by historical standards, but the suddenness of their move might dislodge the financing that underpins stocks. If that scenario turns out to be true — and it is still too early to say that it will — the bond selloff might presage the end of an era for stocks.”

■ It wasn’t quite the end of an era for stocks, although it is certainly true that they peaked a few weeks later as the Global Financial Crisis began to unfold. Equities didn’t regain their 2007 highs until the summer of 2013 after central banks hosed QE liquidity into the markets.

■ What really disturbed us commentators back in mid-June 2007 was that US bond yields had just punched above their multi-year downtrend, and prominent bond gurus like Bill Gross of PIMCO fame were predicting that a bond bear market had only just started. However, that US bond yield ‘breakout’ proved to be a head fake as yields peaked that very week and then plunged as the economy collapsed into recession at the end of the 2007.

■ On the topic of breakouts, I recently recycled Bill Gross’s prediction from 15 years ago that the UK Gilt market is sitting on a bed of nitro-glycerine ([link](#)). I think investors are now coming round to my view. **It’s incredible to realise that UK yields had never broken away from the rest of the G7 pack, until now** – not even during Liz Truss’s brief tenure as PM (at least since 1990 when my G7 yield data begin). We are apolitical on these pages, but it’s clear that the Gilt market’s problems coincide with the UK Labour government taking office, and if as seems likely any new PM tacks to the left, it will surely only get worse. Without the protections other miscreant bond markets have, the UK Gilt market is a bug looking for a windshield.

I want to break free: 30Y Gilt yields – UK breaks away from the G7 pack



Source: Datastream

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The reason I know what ‘Bond King’ Bill Gross was saying in June 2007 is that I had dug out my hard copy of the Global Strategy Weekly from 13 June 2007 entitled *Is the Ice Age over?*

When I got to work this morning, I spotted an email from John Authers saying he was revisiting his 17 June 2007 article, and it had the “*This is the big one*” quote from me predicting imminent Armageddon (*quelle surprise*). As it happened, on this occasion I was correct, not because it was the end of the Ice Age downtrend in bond yields that summer, but because yields had risen high enough to burst the liquidity-fuelled bubbles that had propped up the economy until that point.

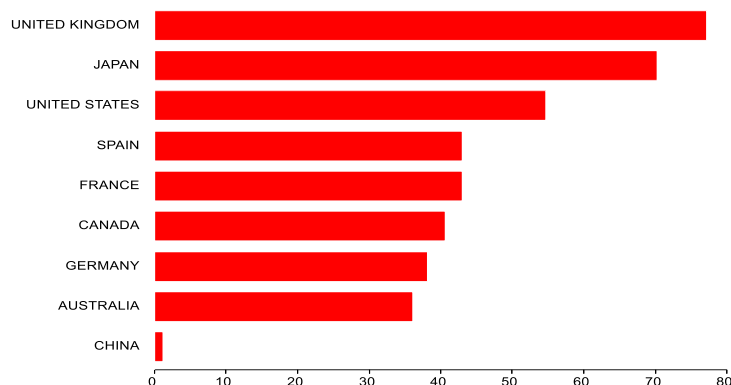
Rereading that 13 June 2007 Global Strategy Weekly is like taking a trip down memory lane (I have them going back to the 1997 Asian crisis, so there are lots more memories I can rekindle). There are notable similarities between now and then, including the unwinding of rate-cut expectations, an upward drift in real yields and a very sanguine view on the resilience of US consumers despite the unfolding sub-prime crisis.

In particular, I noted the following sentence from my June 2007 report, “*The US bond market has made a bet on the US consumer shrugging off a housing crash and record gasoline prices*”. The same is true now. The high gasoline price is remarkably similar, and instead of shrugging off a housing crash, the US consumer is currently shrugging off a ‘crash’ in employment growth driven by AI. But as I pointed out back then, the market can be spectacularly wrong about cyclical resilience, as it was in 2007 and also ahead of the 1990 recession.

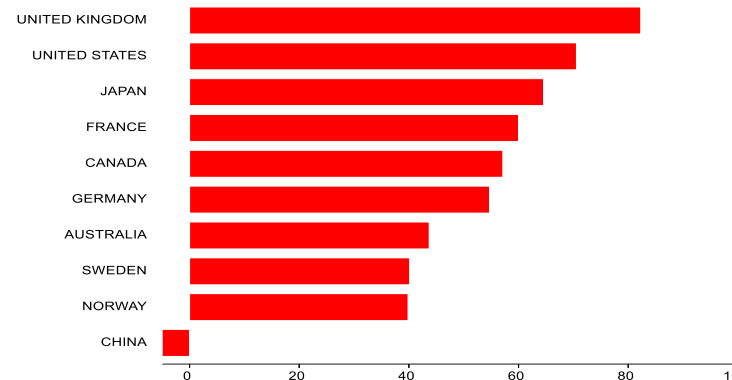
I’m writing more than usual, as I feel we veteran strategists and economists have memories that are now proving invaluable in these febrile times. Anyway, that’s what I told Bloomberg Odd Lots hosts Tracy Alloway and Joe Weisenthal, who recently interviewed me on-camera. We had a wide-ranging discussion about the current situation and why I expect a return to double-digit inflation as well as how an uber-bear like me survives working in a sell-side house. It’s only my third on-camera interview in 15 years, and I didn’t do one for the 20 years before that, so I think that this might be a new trend for me. You can find the Bloomberg video [here](#) and the podcasts [here](#) (I do apologise in advance for my shocking choice of shirt).

Where was I? Ah yes, ranting about surging Gilt yields. I’ve updated the charts showing rising yields in the major bonds since the start of the US/Iran war. I was surprised Japan and even the US are catching up with the UK, especially at the very long end of the curve.

Bp rise in 30y bond yields since start of US/Iran war (27/2/26)...



... and 10y

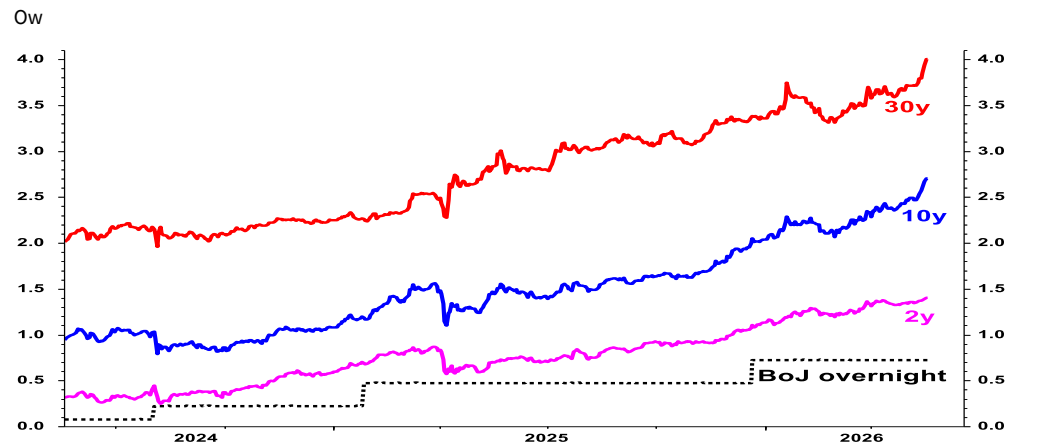


Source: Datastream

We know what’s going on in the US because commentators are fixated on US treasuries – and rightly so. But what on earth is going on in Japan? The chart below shows that yields from 10y onwards have gone parabolic, to the point that 10y yields have moved decisively above the equity dividend yield – for the first time since November 2007, the month the US plunged into deep recession (there seem to be a lot of unnerving comparisons with 2007 coming thick and fast).

We have banged the gong as loudly as we can that the rout in the Japanese bond market is a mega-bearish event for US equities. I can't think of a more alarmist title than that of May 2025, ***Are you ready for Japan to trigger global financial market Armageddon?*** What more can I do?

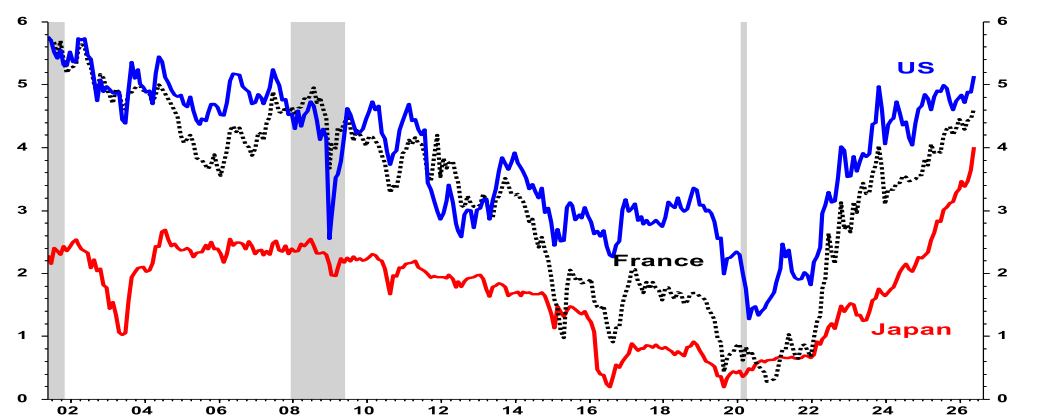
Japanese yields have surged (again) in recent weeks (10y now highest since October 1996)



Source: Datastream

It's pretty obvious to me that the end of Japan's crazy-easy QE programme and a return to 'normality' is having a major deleterious effect on other G7 bond markets, including the US. Do you really think this global bond bear market isn't ultimately going to break the US economy and equity bull market? Are you really feeling that lucky? Actually, the current conjuncture reminds me more of the summer of 1987 (if anyone can remember those events) than the summer of 2007.

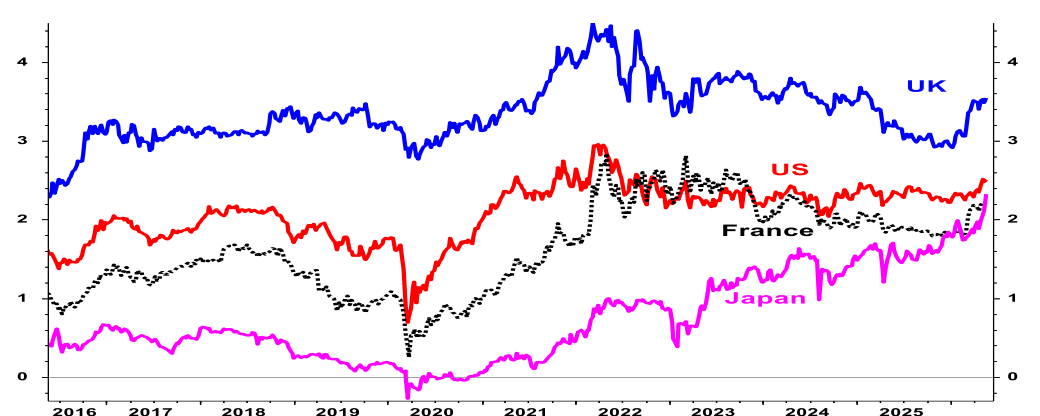
Surging Japanese long bond yields are rocket fuel for the global bond bear market



Source: Datastream

More recently, inflation expectations have surged, especially as the US/Iran war drags on.

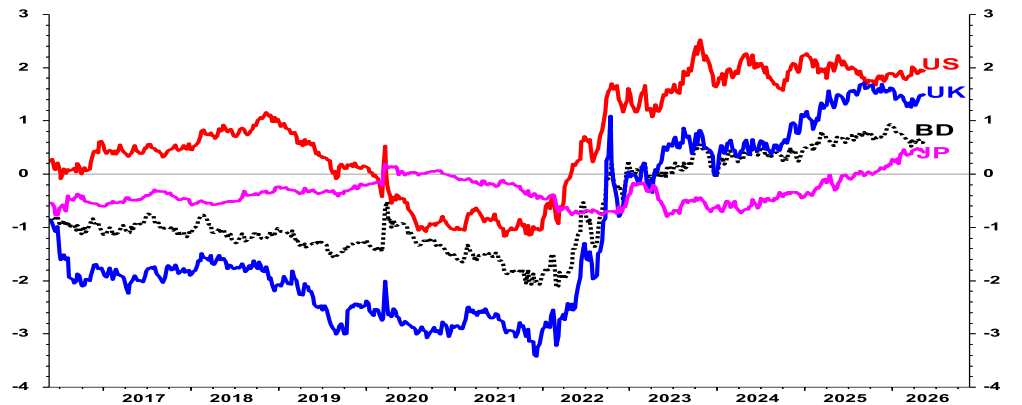
10y inflation breakevens



Source: Datastream

And real yields, although drifting up recently, saw their big paradigm shift higher back in 2022/23.

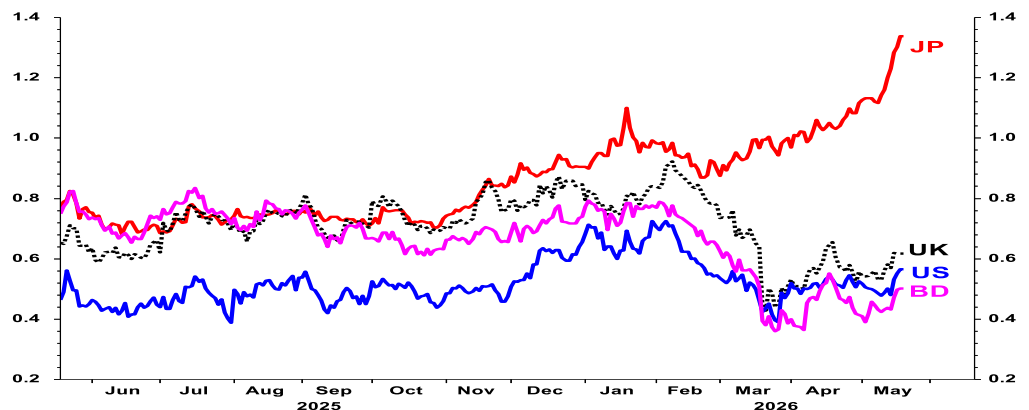
10y real yields



Source: Datastream

The two charts above show Japan *alone* is still seeing sharply rising real rates *and* breakeven inflation measures, and there is a growing feeling that the BoJ is way behind the tightening curve. The latest BoJ meeting saw a hawkish hold, with even more dissenters voting for a rate rise. The best way to gauge just how much the BoJ has lost the confidence of investors this year is the 10-2y curve, which has become alarmingly detached from the other major markets - chart below.

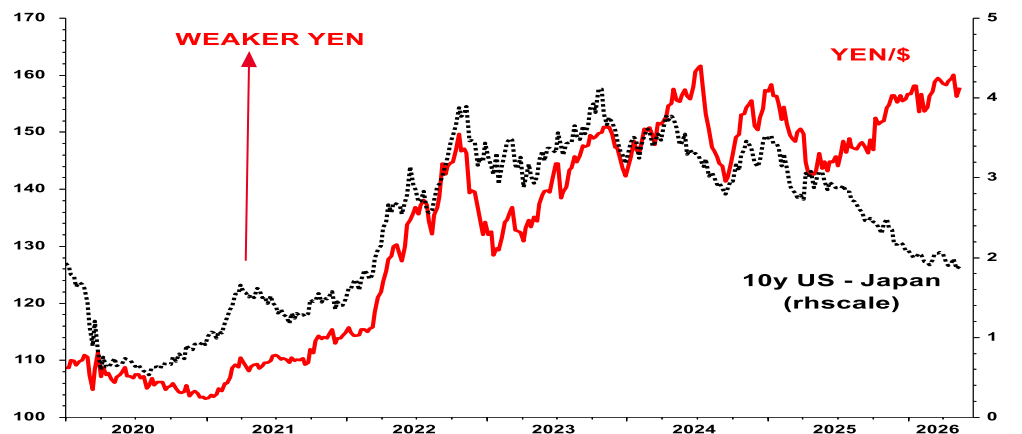
10y-2y curve (%)



Source: Datastream

With PM Takaichi now talking about a supplementary budget to cushion the effects of the war, the JGB market has gone into meltdown ([link](#)). But the clearest evidence that unsustainable government debt dynamics ultimately really do matter is the yen's slide despite interest rate differentials turning decisively in its favour. Make no mistake, this is what a debt crisis looks like.

As Japanese interest rates surge, the falling yen is telling us something (and it isn't good)



Source: Datastream

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APPENDIX

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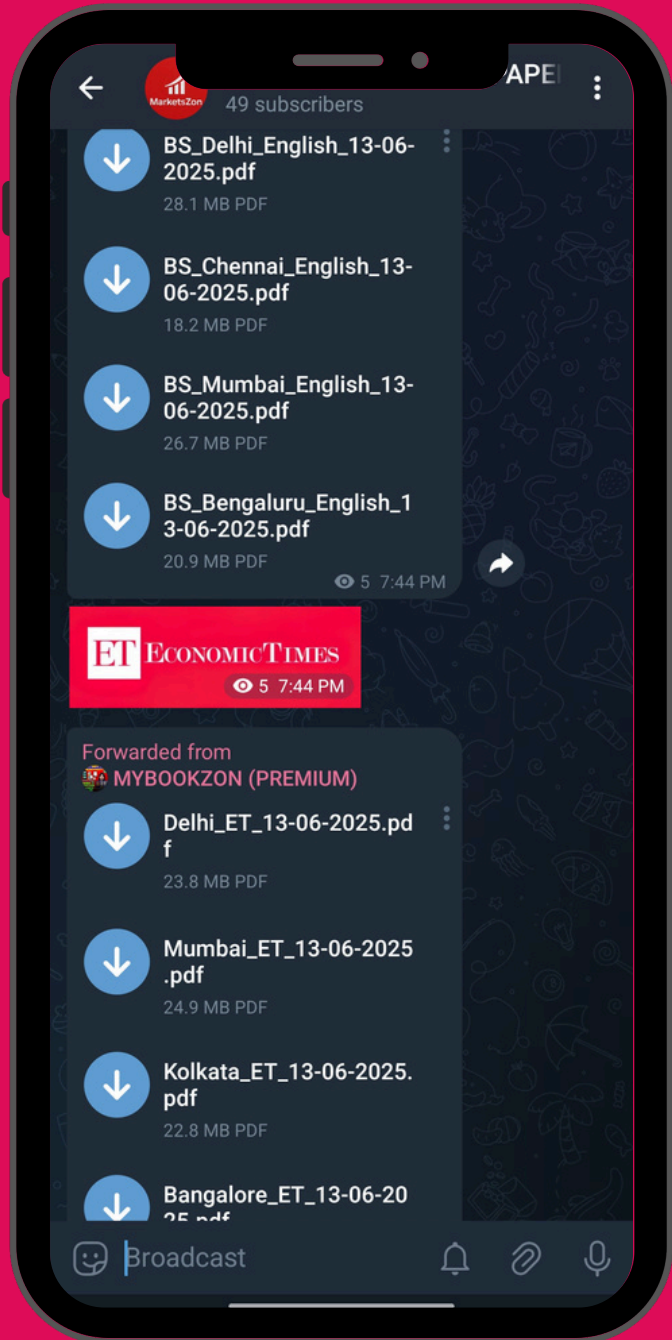
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